

GENRE: (THIRD PERSON) SHOOTER, STEALTH

STUDIO: UBISOFT MONTREAL

PUBLISHER: UBISOFT

*PLATFORMS: XBOX 360, PC

(MICROSOFT WINDOWS)

PUBLISHED: 1999

*REVIEWED ON PC

ACTION-PACKED ROLLERCOASTER RIDE

The hallmark of Splinter Cell games has always been missions that emphasised on quiet and stealthy infiltrations; some of which required players to complete an entire mission without killing a single enemy. For me, patiently lingering in the shadows, watching and eavesdropping on oblivious guards was the real kick in those games. Compared to these past releases in the series, Splinter Cell: Conviction feels more like a cover-shooter than a spy game. Stealth is still an element in the game; however, it no longer rules the design of the game like it once had.

ARTISTIC CONVICTION

The most significant change in the series is in the art department. All other changes in the game's design are apparently centred on this new art direction. Starting with the game's protagonist, Sam Fisher has ditched his trademark night-vision goggles and tactical stealth armour, in favour of urban casual wear. And while there are well-lit and dark areas in equal measure, hiding in shadows has been stylized to meet the new art-style. In Conviction, lurking in shadows bathes the world into shades of gray and Fisher can see in the dark without the need for night-vision goggles. This is because enemies are almost always placed in well-lit areas. The way forward in the missions is mostly about leaving behind a sea of dead bodies. Stealth kills now includes effortlessly taking out enemies while hanging from a ledge or a window pane and a highly effective addition - the Execute move.

A nice bit about this new art direction is the way in which the game's environment has been used to communicate with the player. Mission objectives and grainy videos of flashbacks are projected on the surrounding walls to dramatic effect.

BANG-BANG!

Sam Fisher starts off rather ill-equipped, using stolen piece of a rear-view mirror to peek under doors. However, as the game progresses, he has access to enthusiastically stocked weapon crates that are curiously placed at fixed checkpoints.

Weapons include customary weapon classes of most shooter games—there are pistols, SMG, Rifles and Shotguns. The selection of weapons in each class grows as the game progresses and all of them are upgradable using achievement points.

Just like weapons, the game also has a decent collection of gadgets that are fully upgradable. However, unlike previous Splinter Cell games, you will rarely feel the need to reach into the pockets and use a gadget. Conviction is a relatively fast-paced game with little room, or even the need for much planning or strategising.

VENGEANCE AND BEYOND

Splinter Cell: Conviction has a fairly decent storyline which is delivered through often engaging voice-acting. The plot of Sam Fisher's personal quest to track his daughter's killers is intertwined with another plot which inevitably includes saving the world. We feel that new direction with game-play would have been better justified if the main storyline

would not have essentially culminated into just another mission for the country. Missions are relatively short and as a result the game feels a bit short. The good news is that besides the main campaign, there is a decent amount of bonus content. For instance, in online co-op mode, players assume the role of Archer and Kestrel in a joint effort to recover stolen warheads. Hunter game mode is about progressively clearing the area of enemies, and Last Stand is about surviving waves of enemies, while simultaneously defending an EMP generator. Our online experience with the game was not one of the best. The DRM software for the PC version of the game appears to incessantly ping the Ubisoft servers even during 'offline' play. On a really bad day for the internet connection, it made the game virtually unplayable since every three or four seconds the game would lose connection with the servers and lock the game up. This may be a deal breaker for some. On the plus side, most of the additional game modes do not require another human player.

Splinter Cell: Conviction has its fair share of virtues and vices, and on the balance of things this is a fairly solid game from a neutral perspective. More significantly however, it is the shift of emphasis from stealth to action that is most likely to hurt the fans of series. For those who really want to get this game, it's a hard choice between paying more for the Xbox 360 version or getting the far cheaper PC version and risk having to endure the DRM. **d**